

The RuneScape Gold Rush:
Venezuela's Unlikely Economic Lifeline











Imagine living in a country where killing dragons in a 20-year-old medieval fantasy game pays better than working a real job.

For some Venezuelans, that wasn't a joke. It was how they put food on the table.

Venezuela sits on the world's largest proven oil reserves, with approximately 303.7 billion barrels beneath its soil, more than Saudi Arabia's roughly 267 billion. Yet despite this enormous natural wealth, the country has spent years battling economic collapse, widespread poverty, and political turmoil. Aging infrastructure, insufficient investment, difficulties extracting its heavy crude oil, and international sanctions have all contributed to its struggling petroleum industry.

So how did an oil-rich nation end up with citizens farming virtual gold to survive? Venezuela's economy has long depended on oil exports. When global oil prices crashed in 2014–2015, the country lost a substantial portion of its revenue, sending its already struggling currency, the bolívar, into further decline. Imported goods became increasingly expensive, while government overspending and printing money to cover mounting deficits helped fuel runaway inflation.

By 2018, Venezuela's central bank reported annual inflation of approximately 130,060%, with some independent estimates running considerably higher.

According to the Venezuelan Bolívar Soberano Inflation Calculator, cumulative inflation between 2016 and 2026 exceeded an astonishing 9.38 trillion percent. The bolívar lost value so rapidly that the government repeatedly removed zeros from its currency just to make everyday transactions manageable.

The consequences were brutal. A 2019–2020 national survey estimated that 96.2% of Venezuelans lived in poverty, with 79.3% experiencing extreme poverty. Millions fled the country as food shortages, failing infrastructure, and political repression under Nicolás Maduro's government made daily life increasingly difficult.

In 2019, one estimate placed average daily income at just $0.72 USD. That's where Old School RuneScape (OSRS) enters the picture.







For the uninitiated, OSRS is a massively multiplayer online role-playing game where players spend countless hours slaying monsters, leveling skills, gathering resources, and accumulating gold pieces (GP). That gold can be traded for equipment and supplies through the game's player-driven economy.

But outside the game, an underground market allows players to exchange their virtual gold for real U.S. dollars through third-party websites. The practice, known as real-world trading, is strictly prohibited by the game's developer, Jagex.

For Venezuelans earning next to nothing through conventional employment, however, the potential earnings were difficult to ignore. Players began spending long hours farming monsters like brutal black dragons, which drop valuable resources that can be sold for gold. With a sufficiently leveled character and decent equipment, these dragons are relatively easy to kill repeatedly.

Ten hours of farming could earn around $5 USD, potentially equivalent to nearly two weeks of conventional wages in Venezuela. Some players used their earnings to buy groceries and support their families. Others reportedly saved enough to help finance their escape from the country. What many gamers considered a mind-numbing grind had become a source of income.

And the impact wasn't limited to Venezuela. In March 2019, massive electrical blackouts swept across the country, leaving millions without power or reliable internet access. Venezuelan gold farmers suddenly couldn't log into RuneScape, and their absence was felt in the game's economy.

Prices of commonly farmed resources, including dragon bones and other valuable items, fluctuated as the supply from Venezuelan players was disrupted.

Think about that for a moment: A nationwide power outage in South America was affecting the economy of a medieval fantasy video game.

Of course, not everyone in-game was thrilled about the influx of gold farmers. Large-scale farming increased the supply of certain resources, putting pressure on prices and reducing the profitability of those activities for ordinary players. Many felt their time and effort were being devalued by people who treated the game as a business rather than entertainment. The resentment eventually spilled into the Wilderness, OSRS's notorious player-versus-player region, where adventurers risk losing their equipment and inventory when killed.

Some player clans began deliberately hunting Venezuelan gold farmers, attacking them and taking their hard-earned loot. Meanwhile, Jagex continued cracking down on real-world trading through account bans.

From the perspective of the developers and many players, gold farming threatened the integrity of the game's economy. But for the Venezuelans behind those characters, losing their equipment, or worse, their accounts, could mean losing the income they depended on to feed their families.

It's a strange reality: In a country sitting on hundreds of billions of barrels of oil, some citizens found greater financial opportunity killing imaginary dragons than working conventional jobs. What was supposed to be a virtual currency used to buy swords, armor, and potions had become a way to pay for groceries, support loved ones, and, for some, save enough money to leave Venezuela altogether.









Special thanks to YouTube creator SirPugger, whose reporting helped inspire this article. SirPugger also donated his video's monetization proceeds to a RuneScape community fundraiser that raised $14,567 for the International Rescue Committee, supporting humanitarian relief efforts worldwide, including assistance for Venezuelans affected by the crisis and refugees in Colombia.